HAMASPIK LEOVDEI HASHEM

Cause & Effect and the Will of Hashem

Given Monday 15 June 2026 · HaMaspik LeOvdei HaShem Ch 8 Pt 3

Sefer: HaMaspik L'Ovdei Hashem (Kifayat al-Abidin) — Rabbi Avraham ben HaRambam **Chapter:** Perek 8 (ביטחון — Bitachon and Reliance) — Part 3 **This Week:** Cause and Effect (Sibah u'Mesovav) · The Three Groups of People · Hashgacha Pratit vs. Hashgacha Klalit · The Avot as the Model

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Recap from Parts 1 & 2

The Definition of Bitachon

Complete reliance on Hakadosh Baruch Hu — He is Creator of all, and everything is subservient to His will. Living this way brings **security and serenity** (*betach*). It does NOT mean abandoning the mediums Hashem created — there IS cause and effect — but that cause and effect never excludes Hashem overseeing the entire system.

The Three Categories of Bitachon (from Parts 1-2)

Category	Who	Verdict
1	Prophets who lived off miracles **by divine instruction**	Forbidden for anyone not so instructed
2	Deniers of providence (Aristotle) / those who affirm outwardly but trust intermediaries inwardly	Wrong
3	Those who recognize Hashem oversees all the regular intermediaries — and can change them anytime	**The correct path**

Key Principle Established

Living with Category 3 bitachon means **never going overboard** in pursuit of wealth or health — but this is NOT laziness. The Sages themselves worked; relying on miracles without authorization is arrogance.

Framing — Tonight's Two Targets

This section takes aim at **two errors** about cause and effect:

Target 1 — The Mutakallimun (and those who deny causation)

The **Mutakallimun** were Islamic philosophers (the school of Kalam), some of whom — in order to "preserve" God's total control — **denied cause and effect entirely.** On this view, causation is an *illusion*:

- You think clouds cause rain? Illusion.
- You think wind makes the leaf fall? It would have fallen anyway.
- All apparent causation is really only the direct will of Hashem at each moment.

Rabbi Avraham says this is **clearly wrong** — it contradicts what we see and feel, and it causes religious people to be **mocked by scientists and philosophers.** (Apparently some Jews in his time held this; it's not found among the medieval Rishonim.)

Target 2 — Those Who Believe Science Is Set in Stone

Those who **do** believe in cause and effect and science (like we do) — but believe the laws of nature are **fixed and unchangeable.**

The correct view: Believe in cause and effect, study science, be *enlightened* by it — while recognizing that Hashem oversees all of it and **can change it at any time.**

PART 1 — The Chain of Cause and Effect (Sibah u'Mesovav)

וכן אעיר תשומת לבך על מה שצריך להשיגו לפני מעלת הביטחון, כדי שביטחונך יהיה אמיתי ולא דמיוני /
draw your attention to what must be grasped before the level of bitachon — so that your trust will be real and not imaginary.

Many people think they have bitachon, but it's a nonsensical bitachon — because they don't believe in cause and effect.

כי עליך לדעת שהשם יתעלה... ברא את העולם בתקנה על פי סיבה ומסובב, וקבע לכל תכלית כמה הקדמות
Hashem created the world ordered by cause and effect, and set for every end-result a number of preliminaries.

The Mashal — The Chain of Sustenance

Rabbi Avraham traces the full causal chain of how we are fed:

Link	The Cause
Human/animal life	depends on **nourishment** (food)
Nourishment	comes from **animals or vegetation**
Even animals we eat	are sustained from **the ground** (vegetation)
Vegetation	grows from **the earth + air + water + the sun's heat**
Water for the plants	comes from **rain and dew** (condensed moisture)
Rain	comes from **vapor rising and forming clouds** — ואד יעלה מן הארץ
The rising vapor	is driven by **the winds**, by Hashem's will — רוח סערה עושה דברו

So all sustenance traces back through a long natural chain: food → ground → rain → clouds → vapor → wind.

The Reconciliation — Nature AND God's Will

Rain comes through *nature* — and yet the כמו שאמרה התורה **ירידת המטר באה איפוא מן הטבע** Torah says it depends on Hashem:

Direction	Verse
Rain given	**יפתח ה' לך את אוצרו הטוב** — *"Hashem will open His good treasury"*
Rain in its time	**ונתתי מטר ארצכם בעתו** — *"I will give the rain of your land in its season"*
Rain withheld	**ועצר את השמים ולא יהיה מטר** — *"He will shut the heavens and there will be no rain"*

The Resolution

All natural causes ultimately trace back to וכל הגורמים הטבעיים סופם לחזור אל עילת העילות — for to Him all actions return **the Cause of all Causes** (ולו נתכנו עלילות).

There IS cause and effect, and there IS God's will. They are reconciled because the entire causal system is itself Hashem's, traceable back to Him at every link.

PART 2 — The Three Groups of People

בני אדם לחלוקתם הם בשלוש כתות *.People divide into three groups*

Group 1 — Those Who Ignore/Deny Cause and Effect

This group lumps together several types:

1a — The Simply Uneducated (נבערים מדעת)

אינם חושבים על סיבה ומסובב, אוכלים כמאכל הבהמה

They don't think about cause and effect at all. They eat like animals — **nourished only if food is in front of them**, like monkeys or small children whose minds haven't matured. They can't reason "if I plant this, I'll get that." About them: **ומותר האדם מן הבהמה אין** — *"man's advantage over the beast is nothing"* (Kohelet).

1b — The "Religious" Who Bury Their Heads (added later in the section)

People who **willfully avoid studying** cause and effect, science, nature — because they fear that studying it (like the philosophers) will lead to heresy. They think faith means *not* thinking too much, and they consider themselves **elite and pious** for it.

They derive all their understanding of God only through **emotion/feeling or tradition** ("my father did this, my mother did this") — never through contemplation.

1c — Those Who Deny Causation on "Religious" Grounds (the Mutakallimun type)

Those who studied, understand causation, but **deny it as a matter of "true faith"** — claiming that believing in secondary causes detracts from God's providence. They say all causation is illusory.

כי כפירת הפילוסופים היא מן המחקרים — *"the philosophers' heresy comes from their investigations"* — so (they reason) avoid investigation entirely.

The Problem With All of Group 1

ובאו לידי כפירה בדברים שהשכל מעיד על נכונותם, ואפילו החושים מרגישים בהם

They end up denying things the intellect attests to and even the senses perceive. They become a **laughingstock** (לשחוק... ולעג) before people of understanding.

ואם חושב כן אחד מחכמי ישראל וחסידיהם — הרי הוא... **חילול ה' ממש**

If a Torah scholar or pious person thinks this way — it is, in my opinion and that of anyone with a straight mind, an actual desecration of Hashem's name — as it says: *"These are the people of Hashem, yet they went out of His land."* (Yechezkel).

(Rabbi Kada's example: dinosaur fossils. You can (a) be wholly uneducated about them, (b) know they exist but willfully refuse to engage "lest it contradict Hashem," or (c) acknowledge them but offer some implausible explanation. All three fall into Group 1 — denying what the eye plainly sees. Generally, denying what is blatantly evident in the scientific world is a chillul Hashem.)

Group 2 — The Enlightened Philosophers Who Stop Short

הם בעלי דעת ובינה ומחשבה והתבוננות, שעסקו בחכמות והבינו את סיבותיהם וגורמיהם של כל דבר

Wise, intellectual, scientifically educated people who understand the cause and effect of everything. **Some of them even reached the Cause of all Causes — God** — and grounded their faith on the link between cause, effect, and Creator. They are *"wise men and scientists who keep the Torah,"* outwardly.

Their Fatal Flaw

אלא שגם הללו קצרה דעתם מלהבין את האמת בשלמותה

Their intellect fell short of the *complete* truth. They concluded:

השם יתעלה אינו משנה שום דבר טבעי, ואינו מחולל שום סיבה מתוך מסובב *Hashem changes nothing in nature, and brings about no cause outside the natural order.*

Once nature was created, it runs purely by fixed law. From this they came to:

כפירה בידיעתו יתעלה, והכחשת ההשגחה הפרטית **Denial of God's knowledge of particulars, and denial of individual providence** — for what is there left for God to oversee if everything runs by fixed law?

This is the view of the Greek philosophers (elaborated in the Moreh). About them: **משיב חכמים אחור ודעתם יסכל** — *"He turns the wise backward and makes their knowledge foolish."*

Group 3 — The Truly Religious Who Understand the Secret of Torah

הם שומרי התורה המבינים את סוד התורה

Before defining them, Rabbi Avraham clarifies whom he is **NOT** talking about: not the foolish among Torah-keepers (the Group 1b/1c types — the Amei Ha'aretz, *"לא ידעו ולא יבינו"*, those warned against being **כסוס כפרד אין הבין** — "like a horse or mule without understanding").

What Group 3 Actually Is

מתבוננים אל הסיבות המשניות ומסיקים מהם מסקנות חוקי הטבע, **כדרך שעשתה הקבוצה השנייה... ואינם נופלים מהם**

They contemplate the secondary causes and derive the laws of nature — exactly like Group 2 (the enlightened scientists) — and are in no way inferior to them. They know everything the scientists know; they can hold their own in conversation and debate with philosophers and scientists.

The Crucial Addition

והשם הבינם על ידי תורתו את אשר נשגב מבינת החכמים והפילוסופים, — granted them understanding of what is beyond the grasp of the philosophers

namely, that God **does** know particulars, **does** watch over the human condition, exercises **individual providence (Hashgacha Pratit)** over each person as befits him, and **general providence (Hashgacha Klalit)** over each species, as His wisdom and will determine.

PART 3 — Two Kinds of Hashgacha (Providence)

Rabbi Avraham alludes to two crucial lines (a major theme in the Moreh, developed further by the Ramchal in Derech Hashem):

והשגחתו הפרטית על כל אחד ואחד **כפי שראוי לפניו יתעלה** ובהשגחתו על כל סוג מסוגי הטבע **כפי מה שקבעו חכמתו ורצונו**

Type	Applies To	Nature
Hashgacha Pratit (individual)	**Humans**	Detailed providence over each individual — but **commensurate with the person's level**, relationship, and covenant with Hashem
Hashgacha Klalit (general)	**Species / animals**	Providence over the *species* as a whole, not the individual creature

The Black Cab Analogy (Rabbi Kada)

Imagine someone who owns 100 black cabs and, after five years, wants to downsize to 10. Suppose all 100 are identical — same mileage, same wear, same scratches. He randomly picks 90 to sell and keeps 10. **He doesn't care about any individual cab — only that he has 10 functioning cabs to continue his business.**

That's **Hashgacha Klalit**: Hashem ensures (say) a certain number of sheep exist in the world, without attending to the individual pain, pleasure, or fate of each particular sheep.

Hashgacha Pratit — detailed, individual providence — is reserved for **human beings**. And even among humans, the *degree* of detailed providence is commensurate with each person's level and relationship with Hashem. *(A theme to be developed elsewhere.)*

PART 4 — How Group 3 Lives: Nature Runs by God's Will

אך הוא יתעלה הנה הפועל והמסבב את הסיבות הללו *But it is He who acts and brings about these causes.*

וברצונו מתנהלות הן בדרכיהן הטבעיות and by His will they run in their natural ways — **וברצונו חורגות הן מדרכיהן הטבעיות** and by His will they deviate from their natural ways

The Fire/Oil Illustration

Normally fire burns with oil/wax, not vinegar — that's the law of nature. **But that law operates only because Hashem wills it.** Every time you light a candle, it works because Hashem wills it; and Hashem can, at any time, decree that the usual fuel won't ignite.

When Moshe asked (in Beha'alotecha) how so much food could be provided in the desert, Hashem answered:

היד ה' תקצר? עתה תראה היקרך דברי אם לא *Is Hashem's hand short? Now you will see whether My word comes true."*

ולכן כולם תלויים בעילה הראשונה, עילת כל העילות therefore everything depends on the First Cause, the Cause of all Causes. **ולכן נקרא ה' צור העולמים** therefore Hashem is called the **Rock of the worlds** (the bedrock behind all that happens).

The Constant Discipline

ולפיכך מחזיקים בחזקה בעיקרון זה, ומשווים אותו נגד עיניהם, **ואינם סוטים ממנו עקב הסתכלות מדעית**

They hold firmly to this principle and keep it before their eyes — and do not deviate from it because of scientific study (e.g., the philosophy of Aristotle and his colleagues), nor

because of physical observation (e.g., studying the movements and phenomena of the heavens). They study deeply — and still trace it all back to Hakadosh Baruch Hu.

PART 5 — The Avot as the Model

ובכל הדברים האלו עושים הם כמעשי אבות *.In all these things they act as the Avot did*

The Avot had complete bitachon — **and yet engaged fully in natural means and stratagems**, tracing everything back to Hashem:

Patriarch	The Natural Means / Stratagem	The Recognition
Avraham	Devised a plan to save himself (told Sarah to say "he is my brother" before Paroh/Avimelech) — *"אמרי לי אחי הוא"*	Yet relied on Hashem, not the scheme — and was rewarded with great wealth; a miracle struck Paroh (וינגע ה' את פרעה)
Yitzchak	Worked the land, shepherded, moved his dwelling because of the famine (did NOT sit passively saying "it's all illusion")	Traced success to Hashem — rewarded with **מאה שערים** (a hundredfold)
Yaakov	Devised the elaborate scheme with the rods to obtain his share of the flock	Yet ascribed it entirely to Hashem — **ויצל אלהים את מקנה אביכם ויתן לי** ("God took your father's flock and gave it to me")

אך בכל מעשיהם לא סמכו על חשבונותיהם ויגיעתם, אלא רק על השם יתעלה **.did not rely on their calculations and toil — but only on Hashem In all their actions they**

Therefore divine providence accompanied them in their natural endeavors, and at times **open miracles beyond nature** occurred — *all in the merit of their true beliefs and their bitachon, not because of their knowledge and calculations.*

The Torah's Summary of This Worldview

כי לא על הלחם לבדו יחיה האדם, כי על כל מוצא פי ה' יחיה האדם *Man does not live by bread alone,"* *"but by all that issues from the mouth of Hashem*

We need bread; we must understand how it comes to be — **and we know it comes ultimately by Hashem's decree.**

כי היא חכמתכם ובינתכם לעיני העמים *For it is your wisdom and understanding in the eyes of the" nations"* — the nations will see Israel's intellect and wisdom, in people who *also* recognize .everything comes from Hashem

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PART 6 — The Decisive Response to the Scientist

The final paragraph — the perfect encapsulation of Group 3:

ונמנים הם על אלו שאם יאמר להם הפילוסוף — *they are among those who, if the philosopher says to them*: "Natural phenomena — the sprouting of plants, the birth of horses — have natural ",causes

they answer:

בזאת צדקת — *"In this, you are correct"* (I fully agree with everything in your class)
אך מוטעית סברתך שהסיבות הללו קבועות בלי תמורה — *"But you err in thinking these causes are fixed without change"*

The natural order **deviates from its course according to the will of the One who created nature** and placed its power within these causes.

The Three Proofs from Tanakh

Natural Law	When Hashem Suspended It
Fire burns — He created fire and gave it the power to burn	He nullified that power for **Chananya, Mishael, and Azarya** in the furnace — and strengthened it again afterward, so it **burned the informers** thrown in with them. *(Same fire — but whether it burns depends on Hashem's will.)*
Humans need bread to live	Yet **Bnei Yisrael were sustained by the מן for forty years**

וכן משגיח השם יתעלה על מי שבוטח בו, עד כדי כך שמשנה לו סדרי בראשית Hashem watches over the one who trusts in Him — to the point of changing the very orders of creation for him — for the prophets and the pious, when they subdued their nature before Him.

Summary

The Core Teaching

True bitachon **requires** understanding cause and effect — otherwise it is *imaginary* bitachon. The world runs by a real causal chain (food → ground → rain → clouds → vapor → wind), but the entire system traces back to the Cause of all Causes.

The Three Groups

1. **Deny/ignore causation** — the uneducated, the head-in-the-sand "pious," and those who call causation an illusion. They deny what intellect and senses attest → a chillul Hashem when done by a Torah scholar.
2. **Enlightened philosophers who stop short** — know all the science, even reach God, but conclude nature is fixed and unchangeable → deny individual providence.
3. **The truly religious (correct path)** — know everything Group 2 knows, can debate the scientists as equals, **but trace it all back to Hashem**, who can change nature at any moment.

Two Kinds of Providence

- **Hashgacha Pratit** — individual, for humans, commensurate with one's level
- **Hashgacha Klalit** — general, for species (the black-cab analogy)

The Model

The **Avot** engaged fully in natural means and clever stratagems (Avraham's plan, Yitzchak's farming, Yaakov's rods) — yet relied only on Hashem, and merited both natural success and open miracles. *Man does not live by bread alone.*

Coming Up

Next: **Five (really ten) uses of Bitachon** in different spheres of life — the practical application: in different scenarios (avoiding harm, pursuing benefit, etc.), what is the correct response for a person of true bitachon?

(Schedule note: Rabbi Kada away next week Monday–Wednesday — no shiur Monday/Tuesday next week; this resumes in two weeks.)

B'Ezrat Hashem

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